



Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

The Beast Must Die

The Beast Must Die Que la bête meure

Director: Claude Chabrol

Production Companies: Films La Boétie,
Rizzoli Editore

Producer: André Génovès

Production Manager: Georges Casati

Unit Managers: Alain Belmondo, Patrick Delonneux

Administrator: Henry Dutranno

Assistant Directors: Jacques Fansten,
Michel Dupuy

Script Supervisor: Claudine Gaubert

Screenplay: Paul Gégauff

From the novel 'The Beast Must Die' by:
Nicholas Blake

Director of Photography: Jean Rabier

Camera Operator: Claude Zidi

Camera Assistants: Paul Bonis, Jeannine Rabier

Editor: Jacques Gaillard

Assistant Editor: Catherine Bernard

Art Director: Guy Littaye

Make-up: Louis Bonnemaison

Music: Pierre Jansen

Music Director: André Girard

Sound: Guy Chichignoud

Sound Assistant: Gérard Dacquay

Mixer: Alex Pront

Sound Editor: Monique Fardoux

Sound Effects: Louis Devaivre

Press Representative: Rosine Josem

Cast:

Michel Duchaussoy (*Charles Thénier*)

Caroline Cellier (*Hélène Lanson*)

Jean Yanne (*Paul Decourt*)

Anouk Ferjac (*Jeanne*)

Marc Di Napoli (*Philippe Decourt*)

Louise Chevalier

Guy Marly (*Jacques Ferrand*)

Lorraine Rainer (*Anna Ferrand*)

Dominique Zardi (*police inspector*)

Stéphane Di Napoli (*Charles' son*)

Raymone

Michel Charrel

France Girard

Bernard Papineau

Robert Rondo

Jacques Masson

Georges Charrier

Maurice Pialat (*Police Inspector Constant*)

Jean-Louis Maury

France-Italy 1969

113 mins

Digital (restoration)

The screening on Thu 17 Sep will be introduced by
critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew

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SOUND**

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

Que la bête meure may be Chabrol's *Iliad*. It is, at least according to the description of that work given by the film's protagonist as he helps Philippe with his homework Philippe, adolescent son of the man whom he intends to kill for the death of his own young son in a hit-and-run accident. He offers *The Iliad* as an example of a work which is conventional, even banal, in its story, but unconventional, even 'poetic,' in its details. That, he announces, makes for art. These very words are a fair description of Chabrol's own film. The story line is founded on what are familiar conventions: after his son's death Charles 'tracks down' the killer and passing himself off as an author of children's books, ingratiates himself into his household. At one point, Paul, his host and his victim, walks in on him as he is writing in a small black book. He notices with what caution Charles locks the book up in a disproportionately large and conspicuous wooden box. When he inquires as to whether it is a new manuscript on which Charles is working, Charles answers yes, that one might call it a detective story. For children? Paul wonders a bit perplexed. A detective story, Charles explains, about a child. This little black notebook is a journal of his progress in tracking down the killer and a blunt record of his pre-meditated crime. It also constitutes the off-screen narration to the accompaniment of which the action of the film unfolds. The broad lines of the action follow the conventions of a conventional genre: the detective story.

Chabrol, a lover of Hitchcock, is attracted to the thriller. Throughout his career he has regularly employed the shape of the mystery or detective genre as a superstructure on which to pin his particular idiosyncracies. Often an artist will consciously exploit some known genre or story in order to play against it his own less conventional intentions. The combination generates a certain tension which is part of the aesthetic pleasure of the work. In *Que la bête meure* there is just such a tension between the instantly recognisable mechanics the traditional genre evokes and the highly personal stylistic and emotional preoccupations of the director.

The characterisations are subservient, not to our conventional expectations of three-dimensionality, but to the specific thematic concerns of Chabrol. Charles is a cipher beyond the ruling passions of his life. As for Hélène, those scenes in which Charles is getting to know her are telescoped. He tells us that she is intelligent, charming, etc., but we are given no persuasive indications that this is so. What dominates in her portrait and eventually involves the viewer and Charles in her story is that nervous vulnerability which has already led her, like Charles, to a breakdown after the accident. The scene in which we are allowed to see beyond her surface is on the beach when she confesses in shame that she has slept with Paul. Finally, the beast is, as Charles comments in what is almost an amused tone, a caricature of the completely evil man; he is easy to hate. This is most satisfying to Charles and for us, just as Charles can enjoy his contempt for the decor of Paul's house. There are no complex reactions here. This man mightily deserves some sort of retribution for what he has done to others. But so much of a caricature is he, that at his most awful he is a comic creation, funny and in some perversely aesthetic way, very nearly endearing.

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Le Beau Serge

Thu 3 Sep 21:00; Sun 20 Sep 15:15 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze)

La Rupture

Fri 4 Sep 18:10; Sat 19 Sep 12:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:10

À double tour

Web of Passion
Sat 5 Sep 14:30; Sat 19 Sep 14:50

The Third Lover

L'oeil du malin
Sat 5 Sep 18:20; Sat 19 Sep 20:45

The Beast Must Die

Que la bête meure
Sat 5 Sep 20:20; Thu 17 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew);
Sun 4 Oct 18:10

Les Biches

Sun 6 Sep 18:30; Wed 23 Sep 20:40;
Sun 27 Sep 15:00; Mon 5 Oct 14:30

Juste avant la nuit

Just before Nightfall
Tue 8 Sep 20:45; Sun 27 Sep 12:10; Fri 2 Oct 14:30

Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Mon 21 Sep 20:50;
Fri 25 Sep 20:45; Sun 4 Oct 12:20; Tue 6 Oct 14:30

Philosophical Screens: Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 20:10 Blue Room

Wedding in Blood

Les noces rouges
Thu 10 Sep 18:10; Tue 15 Sep 21:00;
Tue 29 Sep 18:20

Ten Days' Wonder

La décade prodigieuse
Thu 10 Sep 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Sat 19 Sep 18:10

La Femme infidèle

The Unfaithful Wife
From Fri 11 Sep (Preview screening on Tue 1 Sep 20:30)

Violette Nozière

Sun 20 Sep 18:00 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze); Wed 30 Sep 20:30

The Hatter's Ghost

Les fantômes du chapelier
Tue 22 Sep 18:00; Mon 28 Sep 20:35

The Cry of the Owl

Le cri du hibou
Tue 22 Sep 20:55; Mon 28 Sep 18:00

Mean Girls: Claude Chabrol's Dangerous Women

Wed 23 Sep 18:15

The Swindle

Rien ne va plus
Fri 25 Sep 18:15; Sat 3 Oct 18:15 (+ intro by Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

The Colour of Lies

Au coeur du mensonge
Sat 26 Sep 15:00; Sun 4 Oct 15:10

Story of Women

Une affaire de femmes
Sat 26 Sep 17:50; Thu 1 Oct 20:30

La Cérémonie

Thu 1 Oct 18:00 (+ extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance);
Tue 6 Oct 20:45

The Bridesmaid

La demoiselle d'honneur
Sat 3 Oct 15:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:40 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley)

The Girl Cut in Two

La fille coupée en deux
Sat 3 Oct 20:40; Tue 6 Oct 18:00 (+ Q&A with Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

With thanks to

Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

If this detective story is the convention, what are the details which are the poetry of Chabrol's *Iliad*? What is the film really about that places it squarely in the Chabrol canon? The first part of the film is best represented by the tracking shot as the camera passes by, but turns towards Charles clutching the toy bear. This sideways movement occurs at several of the most exciting points in the film. For example, when Paul has just humiliated his own son, Charles, having intervened, chases after Philippe. He finds him on the edge of the quay. The boy has intuitively fathomed Charles' intentions out of some bond of shared hatred. He asks Charles calmly and point-blank why he doesn't kill his father. The intense feelings of this scene are evoked by a camera which begins panning from left to right at a distance like some casual but curious passer-by.

As the dialogue becomes more revealing, the quick quiet music grows more agitated. Simultaneously, we zoom in on the sun-drenched figures, but through a mass of dark foliage which often obscures them in part, sometimes in toto. It is as though the movement past, in striking combination with the focusing closer through intervening patterns, is an effort to detect, to penetrate, to disclose a mystery of the soul. On a smaller scale, there are the obliquely angled tracking shots across table and desks in various scenes as he makes entries into his diary. Sometimes there will be a deliberately obscuring object: a lamp, for example. In characteristic Chabrol fashion a scene at table becomes the vehicle for many things other than eating. Charles, a gourmet of sorts, is celebrating his victory with fine food. While taking evident delight in what is set before him, he calmly tells Hélène who he is and that his intention at the beginning had been to use her. The camera pans from his contained triumph, expressed only by his almost total absorption in his food, past an arbitrarily striking vase of yellow daffodils, to Hélène, always vulnerable, now crumbling. She fumbles with her cigarette and weeps. Meanwhile, the camera has been cutting to the chef who is performing the masterful operation of dismembering a duck and serving it up. The tension between the controlled ceremony of eating on the one hand and Hélène's uncontrolled emotion on the other hand, between the precise classical surface and the groping undercurrent of pain is characteristic of the entire film.

These shafts of revelation penetrating the limpid surface of Chabrol's film are the Homeric details which are unique and personal and for which the conventions of the detective film provide a framework. Charles recounts for Philippe a scene in *The Iliad* in which a warrior is pierced by a spear through the neck. The spear comes out through his mouth, and the warrior bites a cold metal tongue. Chabrol's spearhead tongue is a strangely menacing rotating overhead shot of two fried eggs sizzling gorgeously and monumentally in a frying pan.

Robert Giard, *Film Heritage*, Spring 1971